BOOKS ▼

WHAT LIES BENEATH

***The Dig*, SOWMIYA ASHOK's excavation of the Keezhadi debate, peels back many layers of the mind—in times when history is front-page news**

Reading the words "two days after Pongal" two days after Pongal set up a nice micro time-feel for a book that jaywalks lightly over thousands of years. Time, with a capital 't', is what's at stake here. The *longue durée* beloved of historians. Popular notions of antiquity. The presentism that clouds our past. Or the plotline here: the many summers it takes an archaeologist to stake out a river valley, as in a bone-dry police procedural. The moments it takes for his bosses in New Delhi to jerk their collective knee and fling an excavation report right back at the author *because* it's good work. Maybe too good (to be true)? Maybe his proposed chronology—6th century BC—was a little too heroic?

The other sacralised element here is *place*, in its fullest cultural-anthropological sense. We are in Madurai, western Tamil Nadu, along the banks of the Vagai, the Sangam outback itself. An ancient literary homeland has just found its objective correlative. It's a seductive picture: a Mohenjodaro-like apparition, but with mature Iron Age characteristics and a southern accent. Brick houses, water channels, drainage, planned streets, textile and beads industries. Most of all, writing. A scattered library of potsherd inscriptions, in proto-Tamil Brahmi, audaciously threatens to predate even the Mauryans. The place is Keezhadi—*keezhu*, coincidentally, means 'beneath', so quite the perfect name for a sunken paradise, waiting to be disinterred by caring hands, like an *akam* heroine waiting for her man.

From here, the first-person narrative loops outward in ever-widening spirals, the author's fingers light on the spindle whorl. The story is peeled back in a montage of reels. The *marutham* hinterland, strewn with menhirs, hero stones and the hilltop caves of Jain monks, gradually gets its coastal cousins, with their Roman amphorae, Arabian horse bones and imitation Mediterranean ceramics. We get to the vast necropolis of Adichanallur, and Sivagalai, whose claim to have pushed back the Iron Age to 3345 B.C. has not yet been accused of understatement. Then, frame by frame, text prises open more and more of context: Rakhigarhi, Sinauli, Muziris....

DISARMINGLY POSED AS AN INGÉNUE REPORTER RATHER THAN AS A SAVANT, THE DEBUT AUTHOR LETS IRONY AND WIT DEFLATE THE HUMBUG

The Dig Keeladi and the Politics of India's Past
By Sowmiya Ashok
HACHETTE/ JOHN MURRAY
₹799; 320 pages

The stories are nested within a bubble-wrap of anecdotes: all the sundry folks 'doing' history—geneticists, epigraphists, high school teachers, women labourers—project their own frames. That means all the hardware of history is assembled on the go, and travels light. Sowmiya Ashok poses disarmingly as ingénue reporter rather than savant, letting witty asides do the work. Maybe a couple of times, all the non-linear time-travel tells on her, and perhaps the academic will find the nth reference to kuthu porotta and cargo pants a trifle gratuitous. But this levity is exactly what will lighten the ride for the non-specialist. And the net effect is quietly prismatic: an antidote as much to Dravidian self-absorption as to Aryan chariot-flying. *Blut und Boden* can be slippery terrain anywhere, and here the debutante is wiser than most of her protagonists, leaving the battle trenches, instead lowering herself unshod to the cool earth of the archaeological trench, brushing away the mud from sedimented minds. ■

—Sunil Menon

